

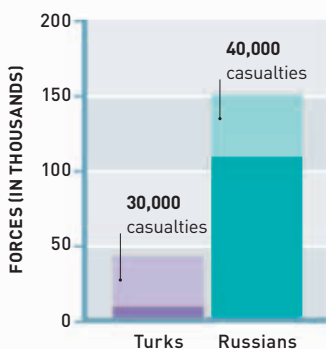


Vasily Vereshchagin's *Mass for the Dead (The Defeated)* shows the aftermath of a Russian defeat during the Russo-Turkish War of 1877-78.

RUSSIA DECIDED TO ONCE AGAIN

DECLARE WAR on the Ottoman Empire on April 24, 1877, in an attempt to aid the Serbians in their fight against the Ottomans (see 1875). Russia was aided by Romania (the united Moldavia and Wallachia). The **Russo-Turkish War of 1877-78** included a five-month siege of the Ottoman Bulgarian town of Plevna, which eventually fell to Russian forces. Russia also managed to take some key fortresses and a truce was called. A settlement was reached on March 3, 1878, known as the **Treaty of San Stefano**, which gave Serbia, Romania, and Montenegro their independence, while Bulgaria was granted some autonomy and put under Russian authority.

However, European powers were not satisfied with this settlement as there were many competing interests. **Prussia** backed Great



Siege of Plevna

Although the Russians eventually overcame the Turks, the small Turkish force heroically held up the Russian advance into Bulgaria.



Afghan fighters

A photograph of Afghan soldiers holding hand-crafted rifles, at Jalalabad, Afghanistan, during the second Anglo-Afghan conflict.

Britain's desire to curb Russian expansion into Bulgaria—which at this point reached the Aegean Sea—by refusing to let Russia extend naval power in the Mediterranean. **Austria-Hungary** wanted to continue occupation of Bosnia and Herzegovina to keep its regional influence intact and stem growing Slav nationalism.

Meanwhile, Britain had signed the **Cyprus Convention** with Turkey. This deal would allow British administration of the island while it remained under Ottoman sovereignty. This allowed Britain to establish a presence and a naval base in the eastern part of the Mediterranean, with the aim of blocking further Russian incursions into the region.

Away from the European diplomatic bargaining table, the British were once again caught up in warfare with Afghans. The **Second Afghan War** (to 1880)

was ignited when British agents learned of negotiations between Afghan leader Sher Ali Khan (1825-79) and Russia. This was compounded by Sher Ali's refusal to receive a British delegation. In November 1878, British forces invaded the region. Sher Ali turned to Russia for support, but was told to make peace with Britain. Sher Ali died the next year and his son, Mohammad Yaqub Khan (1849-1923), signed a **treaty** ceding the **Khyber Pass** to the British. Soon after, a British envoy was murdered and British troops returned to take Kabul. Yaqub was forced to flee. He was succeeded by Abdur Rahman Khan (c. 1844-1901), who ended the conflict and supported British interests.

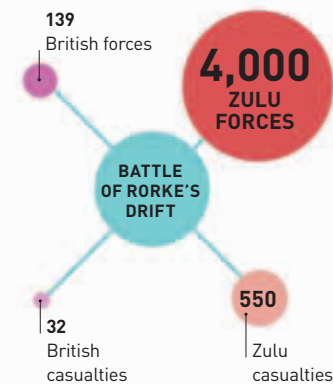


This oil painting shows the defense of Rorke's Drift on January 22, where a handful of British soldiers faced an attack by 4,000 Zulu soldiers.

IN SOUTH AMERICA, PERU,

BOLIVIA, AND CHILE began a dispute over who had control over the **Atacama Desert** region, running along the Peru-Chile border. In the previous decade the valuable mineral **sodium nitrate** had been discovered there. Initially Chilean companies went into the desert to extract the mineral and issues over territorial control soon arose. Chile and Bolivia at first agreed that the 24th parallel was their boundary. But Bolivia, dissatisfied with the deal, entered into a secret agreement with Peru to defend its interests in the desert. Bolivia later seized the property of Chilean companies, prompting Chile's president to send in troops. Chile formally declared **war on Bolivia and Peru** on April 5. The war of the Pacific took place on land and sea, and was not resolved until 1883, with Chile keeping control of the mineral-rich Antofagasta region.

In South Africa, British forces came up against the Zulu nation in the **Anglo-Zulu War**. The British wanted to expand into Zulu territory, but this was met with resistance by King Cetshwayo



Battle of Rorke's Drift

Although the Zulus had some rifles, these were put to little effective use, and superior British firepower won out despite overwhelming numbers.

(1826-84), who organized some 60,000 warriors. The British established a depot at **Rorke's Drift**, which was later attacked by Zulus after their victory in Isandlwana. The Zulus were successfully repelled after 550 warriors were shot by the handful of British troops stationed at the depot. After seven months of conflict, the British managed a final victory over the Zulus in the Battle of Ulundi on July 4, and took control of their territory.

Sunken ship in War of the Pacific

This scene from the Battle of Iquique, during the War of the Pacific, shows Chilean and Peruvian ships. The dispute also included Bolivia.



February 2 Greece declares war on Ottoman Empire

March 3 Treaty of San Stefano gives Montenegro, Serbia, and Romania independence

April 24 Russia declares war on Ottoman Empire

June-July Congress of Berlin meets to discuss the Balkans

November 21 Second Anglo-Afghan War (to 1880) over Afghanistan's talks with Russia

January 11 Anglo-Zulu War begins

January 14 War of the Pacific (to 1883) begins: Chile declares war on Bolivia and Peru

January 22 Battle of Isandlwana: Zulu troops massacre British troops

July 4 Anglo-Zulu War ends with British victory at Battle of Ulundi

February 3 First electric streetlight in Britain

December 31 Thomas Edison gives first public demonstration of incandescent light bulb in Menlo Park, New Jersey, US